Saturday, January 20, 2024
Magh 6, 2080 | Nepal Sambat 1144 | Pohelaathwo Dashami

NATION'S 1ST ENGLISH BROADSHEET

risingnepaldaily.com
Vol. LIX, No. 35 | Pages 8 | Rs. 5 | National Edition

THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL

Address to NAM summit in Uganda

PM stresses justice for shared prosperity

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 19

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has said that the Global Financial Architecture must be reformed to enable countries in special situations to secure finance in achieving their development visions and goals.

"To provide development justice to these countries, the developed countries must fulfill their financing commitment without delay," he said at the 19th summit of Non-Aligned Movement (NAM) as the leader of Nepali delegation.

The summit was organised in Kampala of Uganda on 19 and 20 January under the theme of "Deepening Cooperation for Shared Global Affluence".

He demanded that the international trade must be just, fair, and inclusive which benefits the bottom billions.

"Globalisation, as we believe has not lifted all boats uniformly, rather it has increased income disparities and the concentration of wealth in the hands of a few countries," said PM Prachanda, "Global North must understand that it is not only unethical and immoral but is also unsustainable to leave half of humanity excluded from the journey of prosperity."

The Prime Minister said that the NAM must stress on the economic development and prosperity of its members through the timely achievement of the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development and other internationally agreed development goals.

To overcome the resource deficit, along with North-South and Triangular cooperation, he called for enhancing South-South cooperation as many fellow NAM members have made significant progress both in socio-economic development as well as technological advancement.

Similarly, PM Prachanda said that the NAM should accord high priority to addressing the institutional and capacity constraints being faced by developing and least developed countries on 'Science, Technology, and Innovation', which have become a game changer in today's world.

He maintained that the non-aligned movement should play a greater role in reforming the United Nations. "Our multilateral institutions should be inclusive, transparent, and democratic to ensure enduring peace and shared prosperity. NAM must take the lead to address common and contemporary challenges we are facing," he said.

Stating that the history of human civilisation has abundantly taught that it is only the 'cooperation' through which humanity can achieve greater and better, PM Prachanda said that the NAM itself stands for deepening solidarity, fraternity, and cooperation. We must strive to achieve shared affluence through stronger collaboration among ourselves, he stated.

"Prosperity cannot be the privilege of a few. It must be for everyone and every country. We must create a level playing field within and among the comity of nations so that global affluence will be shared as equitably as possible," said PM Prachanda.

Meanwhile, he said that the consequences of old and new conflicts have engulfed not only the region but also the entire world, particularly the Global South.

This is high time we find an enduring solution for peace and security through political dialogue and diplomacy with respect and dignity for all, he said. He said that though the Movement has continued to struggle for a just, equitable, inclusive, peaceful, and prosperous world order, today's world is full of injustice, inequality, division, discord, and exclusion.

Moreover, protectionism, violent extremism, and war and conflict are on the rise. Likewise, military expenditures and the arms race are soaring.

As the most representative organisation after the United Nations, the non-aligned movement must play a defining role in establishing a just, equitable, and prosperous world for security, stability, and prosperity, Prime Minister Prachanda said.

Talking about Nepal's policy, he said that the country pursues independent, objective, balanced, and non-aligned foreign policy. "Our foreign policy is based on sovereign equality, mutual respect, mutual benefit, and peaceful settlement of disputes. Principles of non-alignment constitute one of the fundamental tenets of Nepal's foreign policy," he said.

As a peace-loving nation, he deplored all kinds of conflicts and geo-political rivalries in the world and said that the conflict situation in Ukraine and Gaza is deeply distressing.

"Nepal looks forward to seeing peace and stability in the Middle East with a two-state solution for Israel and Palestine, living side by side in peace and security within secure and recognised international borders based on relevant United Nations resolutions," he said.



PHOTO: PM'S SECRETARIAT

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' addressing the 19th summit of Non-Aligned Movement organised in Kampala of Uganda on Friday.

> Nepal looks forward to seeing peace and stability in the Middle East with a two-state solution for Israel and Palestine.

'DELIVERING QUALITY HEALTH SERVICE IS PRIORITY OF THE STATE'

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 19

Acting Prime Minister and Minister for Defence Purna Bahadur Khadka has emphasised the production of skilled manpower in the health sector.

Acting Prime Minister Khadka made this remark while inspecting the Nepali Army Institute of Health Sciences (NAIHS) at Barudhakhana, Kathmandu, on Friday.



Acting PM Khadka

Acting PM Khadka said that since the health services run by the private sector are very expensive, and are not easily accessible to the common people, it was the primary responsibility of the state to develop health centres and hospitals at the government and community level and arrange quality health services for the people.

He said that the current government was carrying out various programmes to establish easy and accessible access to health services for citizens

The government has given the capacity development of all public hospitals a top priority, he said.

Acting PM Khadka wished that NAIHS would continue to advance towards producing medical personnel capable of facing the rapidly changing global environment and the health challenges that have emerged with it.

He said that even though he came to the institution for the first time, he was familiar with it and said that the institute, which is an important part of the Nepali Army, was contributing significantly to the production of quality medical manpower needed not only by the Nepali Army but also by the nation as a whole.

With the numerical increase in the number of health institutes and medical research institutes in the country, it is challenging to make the study, teaching and health service delivery agile and quality, he said.

Acting Prime Minister Khadka said, "Health sector is a dynamic sector. Every day new research is being conducted in this field and new treatment methods, technologies and medicines are being invented. We need to adjust and adapt it within our health system."

On the occasion, Chief of the Army Staff Prabhu Ram Sharma, Acting Secretary of the Ministry of Defence and other officers of the Nepali Army were present.

SEARCH FOR FOREIGN INVESTORS TO FEATURE INVESTMENT SUMMIT

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 19

Finance Minister Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat has said that the proposed Investment Summit in April has prioritised investment attraction from foreign investors as well as non-resident Nepalis and the domestic private sector.

In the second meeting of the steering committee of the third Investment Summit on Friday, Finance Minister Dr. Mahat called on the private sector to identify potential foreign investors and projects and present concrete suggestions.

According to a press statement issued by the Office of the Investment Board Nepal (IBN), Finance Minister Dr. Mahat has given special instructions to accelerate policy, legal and procedural reforms and project preparation for the investment conference to be held in Kathmandu on April 28 and 29.

The upcoming investment summit is going to be organised by the government in collaboration with the private sector and development partners.

In the meeting, the Chief Executive Officer of IBN and Coordinator of the Investment Summit Secretariat, Sushil Bhatta, informed about the preparations made so far.

In order to organise the Investment Summit, the government has set up a steering committee under the coordination of the Finance Minister, an implementation committee under the leadership of the Chief Secretary, a technical committee under the coordination of the secretary of the Ministry of Industry, Commerce and Supplies and a secretariat under the coordination of the chief executive officer of the Investment Board Nepal.

In addition, a working group has been formed under the coordination of the Secretary of the Prime Minister's Office (Economic Infrastructure Division) for policy, procedural and legal reforms.

» SEE PAGE 6

Karnali making strides in infrastructure

BY NAVIN SUBEDI
Surkhet, Jan. 19

Looking at the data of the past three and a half years, Karnali seems to have made great strides in physical infrastructure development.

As per the figures released by the province's Ministry of Physical Infrastructure Development, the Karnali government has constructed 82.14 kilometres of motorable and paved roads in 42 months. Roads in Salyan, Rukum West, Dailekh and Surkhet have been blacktopped, with over a dozen roads tarred in Surkhet only. In the whole of Birendranagar Valley, the provincial government has tarred 17 roads. This includes the road near the office of Ward No. 8 of Birendranagar Municipality (180 metres), the Elite Boarding School Hotline Road (80 metres), Shankarchowk-Pritana Road (1,400 metres), Batuli-Acharya Tea Shop Road (123 metres), Alayachaur Road (250 metres) and one kilometre of road connecting the valley's park with some major tourist destinations.

The Sundarmarg Road (550 metres), northern section of the Chandraman Chowk Road (630 metres), the road leading to the Fulbari Chowk (250 metres) and the Kharkholi Road (500 metres) have also been blacktopped.

Some roads, though, remain to be blacktopped because of contractors' negligence, the ministry said.

However, Ramesh Subedi, spokesperson for the ministry, said that the provincial government had focused on opening tracks and gravelling roads rather than blacktopping because not all parts of the province had road access. That is why he said it was irrelevant to say that the province had only blacktopped 20 to 30 kilometres of road a year.

According to the ministry, the government has so far opened 102.94 kilometres of new track this fiscal year. Over the past three and a half years, it has opened 2,527.05 kilometres of track.

Similarly, the Karnali government has gravelled 464.61 kilometres of road in the same period and built 226.23 kilometres of drainage, 71 suspension bridges and 27 motorable bridges. The ministry claimed that it had also constructed 11 communal buildings, 291 residential houses and 241 homes for economically disadvantaged people.

"It is not that the province has not done anything. But its achievements have been concealed by those seeking to discredit it," Subedi said.

The Physical Infrastructure Ministry has been given a budget of Rs. 10,114,261,000 this fiscal year. Of this, Rs. 9,835,543,000 is the capital or development budget. The ministry had only been able to spend 7.15 per cent of this development budget by January 14.



PHOTO: NAVIN SUBEDI/TRN

A four-lane highway passing through Birendranagar in Surkhet district.

Pangolin in Nepal awaits conservation

BY HARI KOIRALA
Urlabari, Jan. 19

Kerabari Rural Municipality in north Morang has initiated a conservation campaign for pangolins (salak), a species at the brink of extinction worldwide. This rare species finds itself in a dangerous situation, as its habitat is rapidly shrinking because of human encroachment.

These unique animals are among the most trafficked mammals in the world. Pangolins are smuggled, particularly for their meat and hide from Nepal to China and Vietnam due to their perceived medicinal properties.

The indiscriminate clearing of dense forest areas in the name of the community and scientific forestry has led to the crisis of habitat for pangolins.

Until a few years ago, a significant population of pangolins used to thrive in the Chure area of North Morang. Even today, their habitat can be found in Kerabari and Miklajung Rural Municipality, as well as the Chure area of Letang Municipality.

Kumar Bahadur Bishwakarma, President of the Model Permaculture Learning Centre, engaged in local pangolin conservation, said that the primary source of the pangolin's diet comprises termites and insects.

Pangolin's meat is considered a delicacy but scales are their most prized parts. On one hand, the habitat of Pangolins is shrinking and on the other hand, the smuggling of Pangolins has increased by many folds.

Ganga Limbu, a member of the Vertical Biodiversity Fund, said that pangolins are considered farmers-friendly species as they fertilise the soil and do not harm humans in any way. Pangolins are known as farmer-friendly wildlife because they loosen the soil and increases fertility.



Two organisations named Vertical Biodiversity Fund and Model Permaculture Learning Thalo have been active in Nnorth Morang since 2017 to protect pangolins.

The National Parks and Wildlife Protection Act has placed the pangolin on the list of protected wildlife.

Out of the eight species of pangolins, two species considered rare in the world, black salak (Chinese pangolin) and copper salak (Indian pangolin) are found only in Nepal.

Of all the pangolins found in Nepal, the Chinese pangolin stands out as the only internationally endangered wild animal. Bhojraj Kafle, Chairman of the Vertical Biodiversity Fund, mentioned that the organisation is actively involved in efforts to combat poaching and smuggling of these animals. Their initiatives include treating injured pangolins, pinpointing their habitats, educating locals about the significance of these animals, and raising public awareness of their conservation.

According to Kafle, the Fund is working on pangolin conservation in Morang, Sunsari and Sankhuwasabha.

Pangolins are typically located in forests at an elevation of around 2,000 metres above sea level. They are known for their shy and sensitive nature and prefer seclusion. Their reproductive rate is notably low, as they give birth to only one offspring at a time.

The survival rate of their offspring is very low, so it is crucial to create an environment where pangolins thrive, said Bishwakarma.

Durga Prasad Kattel from Kerawari-5 Satisale said that the habitat and food sources for these insect-eating animals have shrunk.

"Simply safeguarding their habitat is insufficient, termite mounds are no longer visible in the forest. The indiscriminate intrusion of human activities has obliterated these mounds, "said Kattel.

» SEE PAGE 6

NPC VICE-CHAIR MEETS WB COUNTRY DIRECTOR

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan 19

National Planning Commission (NPC) Vice Chairman Dr Min Bahadur Shrestha and World Bank (WB) Country Director for Maldives, Nepal and Sri Lanka, Faris Hadad-Zervos held a meeting today.

In the meeting took place at the NPC office in Singha Durbar, discussions were held on how to synchronize between the WB's Country Partnership Framework (CPF) and the 16th periodic plan of Nepal, the NPC Vice-Chair's Secretariat stated. During the meeting, Vice-Chair Shrestha said that the 16th plan which is currently in drafting process will be centred on infrastructure building, social sector reforms, increasing production and employment generation.

He stated that the 16th plan gives special attention to identify and resolve the existing structural problems. The NPC Vice-Chair expressed gratitude to the development partners, including the WB, for their assistance to Nepal.



PHOTO: RSS

Simkot airport in remote Humla district in Karnali province.

FOUR ARRESTED WITH RS. 23M

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 19

The team of Department of Revenue Investigation arrested four people with more than Rs 23 million of undisclosed sources today.

The seized amount is speculated to be of illegal 'hundi' transaction.

Director General of the Department, Nawaraj Dhungana, told Rastriya Samachar Samiti (RSS), that the team arrested Naresh Agrawal and his assistant with that amount.

The amount was found while the team of the Department raided the house of Agrawal, it was said. The seized amount is speculated to be of illegal 'hundi' transaction. The Department is preparing to take the date from the court to detain the arrested ones for forwarding the investigation into the case, according to Director General Dhungana.

Problems relating to Make in Nepal Swadeshi Campaign discussed

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 19

The Confederation of Nepalese Industries (CNI) has discussed the problems facing the industrial members involved in the Make in Nepal Swadeshi Campaign and their solutions as well.

In the presence of Chief Secretary Dr. Baikuntha Aryal, secretaries of the Ministry of Industry, Commerce and Supply Mukund Prasad Niraula and Narayan Prasad Sharma Duwadi and others, the policy issues to be taken for the promotion of the domestic industries were discussed in the Swadeshi Meet and Greet held in the capital on Thursday.

CNI President Rajesh Kumar Agrawal said that the Confederation was conducting policy advocacy for the industries involved in the Swadeshi Campaign, assisting in networking, marketing and promoting domestic products.

According to a press statement issued by the CNI on Friday, President Agrawal said that they were working to give policy suggestions in the annual budget for the promotion of domestic products, cooperate with national and international organisations to increase access of indigenous goods and services to internal and external networks and operate the Business-to-Business (B2B) portal.

The CNI has recently joined the "Agora" platform of the United Nations Capital Development Fund (UNCDF).

He expressed his belief that the platform would be an effective way for domestic products to reach the international business network.

Stating that the provision to provide up to 8 per cent cash subsidy for export promotion was producing positive results, he requested the government to encourage the products involved in the Make in Nepal Swadeshi Campaign by giving an additional one per cent export subsidy.

He said that the Confederation has completed all the procedures and submitted an application to the Department of Industry for the collective trademark of Swadeshi.

Chief Secretary Dr. Aryal said that the government would create needed environment for government and public institutions to purchase domestic goods and urged the private sector to purchase indigenous goods as well.

Stating that the government has taken ownership of the Make in Nepal Swadeshi Campaign since its inception, he said that the issues such as land delimitation and law amendments raised by the Confederation to promote domestic industries were a priority.

Chief Secretary Dr. Aryal requested the Ministry of Industry, Commerce and Supplies to send a proposal regarding Bilateral Investment Agreement (BIA) to the Council of Ministers to attract foreign investment.

He suggested conducting a campaign to inform the common consumers about the logo and its features, which are being used by the member industries of the Make in Nepal Swadeshi Campaign.

Industry Secretary Niraula said that the directive to purchase domestic goods, even if they were 20 per cent more expensive, was in the final stage.

Stating that the government was trying to encourage domestic production, he said that the policy suggestions given by the Confederation were worthy of consideration. He said that these suggestions could not be implemented overnight, but they would be implemented step by step.



PHOTO: TRN

Chief Secretary Dr. Baikuntha Aryal speaking about policy issues for the promotion of the domestic industries for Swadeshi Meet in Kathmandu on Thursday.

Power generation resumes from Surnayagad Hydropower

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Baitadi, Jan. 19

After the Surnayagad Hydropower Project, which has remained closed for one and a half years, has been restored, the power has been supplied to the locals and water has been available to irrigate the farmlands.

The 299 KW capacity hydroelectric project, which was closed due to the dilapidation of its panels, came into operation after repairing the powerhouse. The electricity project built in 1990 in Patan of Baitadi for irrigation and electricity is the oldest hydro project in Baitadi.

Janardan Poudel, chief of Nepal Electricity Authority, Baitadi Distribution Centre, said that after repairing the canals and panels, the electricity generation has begun since Tuesday.

He said that despite having a power generation capacity of 200 kilowatts, more water is used for irrigation in winter, so they started generating only 100 kilowatts of electricity and connected it to the national transmission line.

A technical team from the Project Development Department of the NEA and Baitadi Power Distribution Centre completed the repair work within a month and started generating electricity.

Since irrigation and electricity generation have to be done from the same canal, it is said that electricity will be generated only five hours a day. Kesh Khatri of Patan Municipality-6 said that the locals were happy after power generation began by repairing the closed project.

Riverside Resort's food certified excellent

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 19

Food at Siddharth Riverside Resort along the Prithvi Highway has been certified as 'Excellent'. The Regional Food Technology and Quality Control Office, Hetaunda, has given the resort a certificate of the highest standard of category 'A'.

The Department of Food Technology and Quality Control (DFTQC), the apex body under the Ministry of Agriculture and Livestock Development and responsible for the implementation of food laws and regulations, has been classifying the food hygiene level into 4 categories: excellent, good, satisfactory and normal. Kathmandu and Pokhara are at a distance of 100/100 km from this resort located in the middle of Prithvi Highway.

The first five-star hotel 'Siddharth Villasa' in Bhairawa, the luxury resort 'Siddhartha Vilasa Vanwas' in Sauraha, and around 3 dozen outlets including star hotels, resorts, cottages and cafes of Siddharth Group are in operation in various cities of the country.

Sarlahi farmers getting good prices for vegetables

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Sarlahi, Jan. 19

The vegetable farmers of Sarlahi district are now happy after every green vegetable they have produced started getting good prices for the past few days. Tomatoes, beans and brinjal are produced immensely in the district.

The price of these vegetables has doubled this week compared to their prices a week ago. The farmers who often used to complain that they were unable to recover the production cost in lack of market, have got relief after their products began fetching better prices.

The beans produced by the farmers were sold at Rs. 18 to Rs. 20 per kg until a week ago. Currently, the farmers are selling beans at Rs. 35 to Rs. 40 per kg, according to Lalbandi Wholesale Vegetable Market.

Similarly, farmers are selling a crate of 25 kg tomatoes for Rs. 500 to Rs. 600. Until 10 days ago, a crate of tomatoes cost Rs. 250 to Rs. 300. Mohammad Usman, a trader at Lalbandi Wholesale Vegetable Market, said that large-sized tomatoes were being sold at Rs. 600 per crate and small-sized at Rs. 500 per crate.

According to him, the prices of vegetables started soaring from the eve of Maghe Sankranti. Traders said that the demand for vegetables from outside markets had also increased, leading to an increase in vegetable prices. Brinjal, which was difficult to sell even at Rs. 10 to Rs. 15 per kg, is now being sold at Rs. 40 per kg.

Ramdas Ray, a farmer of Lalbandi Municipality-11, Hirapur, expressed his happiness that he was getting good prices by selling vegetables for the past few days. Vegetables are grown commercially in Lalbandi, Harion, Ishwarpur, Chandranagar, Haripur, Barhathwa and Godaita of the district.

The vegetables produced by the farmers here are consumed in the weekly market of Sarlahi and supplied to Kathmandu, Pokhara, Narayangadh, Birgunj, Gaur and other markets.



PHOTO: TRN

Tomatoes for sale in the market in Sarlahi.

Ratnanagar festival brings 180,000 visitors till 9th day



PHOTO: TRN

Visitors at Ratnanagar Festival on Friday.

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 19

The flow of visitors at the 12th edition of Ratnanagar Festival organised by the Ratnanagar Chamber of Commerce and Industry, Chitwan, at Tikauli Chaur is increasing every day. Thousands of people are observing the festival every day, said Shankar Giri, President of the Ratnanagar Chamber of Commerce and Industry and coordinator of the festival organiser committee.

The special features of the festivals like agricultural products, motorboats and cultural houses in the festival are attracting visitors. Maize crops have been planted in the agricultural section of the festival area. A statue of maize and a house built from the maize stands here. Likewise, a statue of a cow with a calf sucking milk has been constructed in the agricultural complex. It also has a fish pond and a mushroom tunnel.

According to the organiser, there is a crowd of people watching and taking photos of these features in the agricultural complex. Likewise, visitors are attracted to the traditional houses of different castes built in the festival venue. According to Giri, the number of people who took a motorboat ride, which is kept for the first time in the history of the Ratnanagar Festival, was remarkable.

Similarly, the goods produced by women entrepreneurs are also relatively sold during the festival. The women have produced homemade pickles, handicrafts, gundruk and other materials and exhibit them for sale at the festival. The dairy products produced by the cooperatives have also found a good market in the festival. Agriculture and tourism have been given priority in the festival. There are 450 stalls, including industry, trade, agriculture, tourism, local art and culture in the festival.

It is expected that more than 300,000 visitors will observe the festival and the turnover will be more than Rs. 250 million, Giri said. He said that the observers have been visiting the festival as expected and the festival is getting closer to achieving its objective. About 180,000 visitors have visited by Friday, according to the organiser. Up to 36,000 visitors have observed the festival in a single day. The festival that kicked off on January 11 will continue till January 22.

Construction of Sainamaina Ring Road in final stage



PHOTO: TRN

Sainamaina Municipality in Rupandehi and the Asian Development Bank officials signing an agreement to implement the development project within the urban area of the Municipality, Friday.

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Butwal, Jan. 19

After an agreement was reached between Sainamaina Municipality of Rupandehi district and the Asian Development Bank, the country's longest ring road will be completed this year.

Sainamaina Municipality and the ADB have signed the agreement to implement the development project within Sainamaina Municipality under the Urban Area Improvement Programme.

Janak Thapa, chief administrative officer of Sainamaina Municipality, said that after the agreement, the construction of the Sainamaina ring road, which is about 57 kilometres long, will be completed within the current fiscal year.

Currently, around 21 km of road section is about to be completed in wards 10 and 11 of the municipality. Adjoining roads connecting with ring roads will also be constructed within this fiscal year, said Thapa.

Sainamaina Ring Road is one of the longest ring roads in Nepal. Thapa said that the completion of the rest of the construction work on the 57 km long ring road would provide an impetus to the development of Lumbini Province.

The Asian Development Bank and Sainamaina Municipality signed the project worth Rs. 2.20 billion at the Ministry of Finance in Kathmandu on Wednesday.

Mayor Phanendra Prasad Sharma, Chief Administrative Officer Janak Thapa, Secretary of the Ministry of Finance Dr. Krishna Hari Puskar and Country Director of Asian Development Bank Arnaud Cauchois signed the agreement, said Thapa.

The Sainamaina ring road is being constructed to connect Ward No. 1 to 11 of Sainamaina Municipality, which stretches about 20 kilometres in the north and seven kilometres in the south of the main highway. The construction contract was signed on May 31, 2017, and a target was set to complete the project by November 23, 2021.

However, negligence on the part of the contractor and lack of budget left the construction work in limbo for about six years. The Sainamaina Municipality has informed that bids will be invited soon for the construction of the remaining 21 km of the ring road.

104 local levels selected for innovation-based economic development programme

BY RADHAKRISHNA DUMRE/RAMESH BISHWOKARMA
Waling/Gulmi, Jan. 19

Projects under the innovation-based local economic development programme will be implemented through a cost-sharing model. Metropolitan and sub-metropolitan cities are required to cover 30 per cent of the costs of the project, which can have a total cost of up to Rs. 10 million, while municipalities are required to cover 25 per cent of the costs.

A total of 104 local levels have been selected from all over the country to be a part of the innovation-based local economic development programme. Of them, 20 were selected from the Koshi Province, 17 from the Madhes, 17 from Bagmati, 12 from Gandaki, 11 from Karnali, 15 from Lumbini and 12 from Sudurpashchim. They were selected by the Ministry of Federal Affairs and General Administration (MoFAGA).

Among the dozen selected from Gandaki, four were selected from Syangja. This is the highest number selected from any one district in the province.

The ministry has chosen Waling Municipality, Kaligandaki Rural Municipality, Aandhikhola Rural Municipality and Biruwa Rural Municipality to participate in the programme from Syangja.

Rural municipalities need only cover 15 per cent of the costs of the project. The total cost of the project can be up to Rs. 7.5 million.

Similarly, Vyas Municipality, Shuklagandaki Municipality and Myagde Rural Municipality have been selected from Tanahun, Barpak Sulikot Rural Municipality and Siranchowk Rural Municipality have been selected from Gorkha, Jaimini Municipality has been selected from Baglung, Bihadi Rural Municipality has been selected from Parbat and Madhyabindu Municipality has been selected from Nawalpur.

Similarly, of the 15 local levels selected from Lumbini, six, Resunga Municipality, Dhurkot Rural Municipality, Chhatrakot Rural Municipality, Malika Rural Municipality, Chandrakot Rural Municipality and Isma Rural Municipality were selected from Gulmi.

Projects under the innovation-based local economic development programme will be implemented through a cost-sharing model. Metropolitan and sub-metropolitan cities are required to cover 30 per cent of the costs of the project, which can have a total cost of up to Rs. 10 million, while municipalities are required to cover 25 per cent of the costs.

Likewise, rural municipalities need only cover 15 per cent of the costs of the project. The total cost of the project can be up to Rs. 7.5 million.



PHOTO: SIRAN KHAN/TRN

As the fuggy and cold weather continues and the temperature is dropping significantly in Tarai belt by affecting daily life of the people, the denizens of Nepalgunj seek the traditional way of beating the cold, Friday.



PHOTO: TRN

Nepal National Employees' Association, 2063, The Press Centre Nepal and Shramjibi Patrakar Sangh of Gorkhapatra chapter jointly welcoming newly appointed two advisors of the Gorkhapatra Corporation (GC), managerial, financial and printing advisor Ram Krishna Adhikari and legal advisor Sushila Chaudhari, Friday. They were appointed as advisors by the Council of Ministers on 21 December 2023.

'Congress with Community' campaign deferred again

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 19

The Nepali Congress is likely to reschedule its campaign 'Congress with Community' because of the National Assembly election slated for January 25. Earlier, the NC had scheduled the campaign from January 21 to February 5.

NC general secretaries Gagan Kumar Thapa and Bishwo Prakash Sharma, and chief secretary Krishna Prasad Paudel on Thursday discussed rescheduling the campaign.

Paudel informed that the calendar was affected due to the National Assembly Election.

He said the campaign would be launched on January 26, a day after the NA election.

As per the new schedule, the party will launch the campaign by holding a programme in all seven provinces on January 26, the central representatives for the campaign will reach all local levels by January 27, and the campaign will be held in 6,643 wards on the Martyr's Day, on January 30.

"We collect the people's views on the performance of the government and the NC from ward level," he said. Earlier, the NC had postponed the campaign citing the Jajarkot earthquake.

The NC planned to run the campaign only in 59 districts stating that it was impossible to run the campaign in five districts of Karnali Province, two of Gandaki and one in Koshi Provinces because of cold weather.

The campaign will not be held in Kalikot, Dolpa, Mugu, Humla, Jumla, Mustang, Manang and Solukhumbhu districts.

Meanwhile, the party on Wednesday held an orientation for the central representatives deployed in the campaign. The party has planned the campaign with the objectives of strengthening party organisation and collecting information about the performance of the government.

TUTH issues notice to MRs to refrain from advertising medicines, other goods

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 19

Tribhuvan University Teaching Hospital (TUTH) has issued a strict notice, urging Medical Representatives (MRs) to refrain from advertising medicines and other goods during patient examinations. The directive, released on Thursday, specifically urges MRs to refrain from entering the Outpatient Department (OPD), wards and Operation Theatre (OTs).

The hospital has issued such notice in response to the complaints that emerged after unauthorised people started collecting blood samples, taking them to private labs and charging high rates for the tests.

The notice serves as a formal communication to all stakeholders, emphasising the importance of maintaining an environment conducive to the well-being of patients. The hospital has explicitly warned that any individual found engaging in activities that disrupt patient treatment will face repercussions under established rules and regulations.

The teaching hospital remains committed to upholding high standards of patient care and ensuring that medical examinations proceed without unwarranted interruptions. This proactive stance aims to safeguard the hospital's reputation and prioritise the health and comfort of patients undergoing treatment, according to the notice.

YOUNG SCIENTISTS' SUMMIT 2024 TO BE HELD NEXT MONTH

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 19

Nepal Polymer Institute (NPI) and Uniglobe Secondary School/College (UGSS) are set to jointly organise the eighth Young Scientists Summit on the latter's premises in Kamaladi, Kathmandu next month.

The summit, to be held on February 5 and 6, is being organised in collaboration with the Ministry of Education, Science, and Technology; Nepal Academy of Science and Technology (NAST); National Innovation Centre (NIC); United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organisation (UNESCO); Research and Development Society (RDS) Nepal; and Science Teachers Association of Nepal (STAN), informed a press statement released by the organisers.

Students of grades 8 to 12 from across the nation will be allowed to take part in the summit, the statement said.

The students will compete in six categories – Engineering and Robotics, Life Sciences, Chemical and Environmental Sciences, Physical Sciences, Mathematics and Computer Science, and Indigenous Knowledge and Technology.

Girl child to be granted cash



PHOTO: TILACHAN PANDEY/TRN

Kaligandaki Rural Municipality which has introduced a policy depositing Rs. 10,000 in the bank account of each baby girl born in the rural municipality, Friday.

BY TILACHAN PANDEY
Tamghas, Jan. 19

Kaligandaki Rural Municipality in Gulmi district has introduced a policy to deposit Rs. 10,000 in the account of each baby girl born in the rural municipality.

Chandra Bahadur Thapa, the head of the Health Department, informed that the rural municipality would establish a revolving fund of Rs. 10,000 for each baby girl born in Kaligandaki Rural Municipality.

"The policy aims to support girls in their higher studies as the fund would amount to approximately Rs. 40,000 by the time they become eligible to withdraw it.

As per the provision, only the account holder can withdraw the fund after obtaining the citizenship certificate."

Chief Administrative Officer Naresh Giri said since the working procedures have already been passed, implementing the policy would not face any legal problems.

Rural Municipality Chairperson Bed Bahadur Thapa said that the policy was introduced to end discrimination against girls and provide financial assistance to girls during their adolescent years.

According to the Health Department, approximately 40 girls were born in the rural municipality in the past fiscal year. The rural municipality had initially provided Rs. 5,000 to each of them. However, the department decided to establish the revolving fund as the provision of providing Rs. 5,000, failed to create a significant impact.

The department has received applications from 20 girls born in the current fiscal year.

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

In the depth of winter I finally learned that there was in me an invincible summer.
-- Albert Camus

Building Rational Political Order



Dev Raj Dahal

Political order is a public good. It is defined by the governing arrangements of the state and society that underlie basic values, rules, principles and institutions to regulate the conduct of all population. Constitutional dispensation of the state outlines the balance of security, liberty, equality and livelihood of individuals with the community imperative where deviants, power brokers and free-riders are disciplined by the moral code, penal system and law enforcement. Liberty and order are interrelated: one cannot flourish without the other's proper consideration. Citizens need law-abiding civic habits and virtues. In a large passage of life, acquiring civic enlightenment and guts helps Nepalis with a range of options to see ahead, utilise public institutions, whet confidence to overcome difficulties and mitigate them one by one to produce a rational political order.

Nepali government's redistributive measures from the rich to the poor with affordable tax and cash transfer as incentives seek their compliance with national laws. It is an essential but not sufficient economic pie to upswing the social mobility of Nepalis. This goal can be achieved by common educational, health and job opportunities and sociability of conduct, not their split between the public and the private and reinforcing pre-existing misery and social cauldron of repressed despair. The vision, will, integrity and wisdom in Nepali leaders are deemed vital qualities to shape a healthy political order so that people are not lulled into a haze of alluring hope soon to be flirted with anomie, social struggles and disorder.

Peoples' wellbeing

A political order cannot become healthy unless leadership promotes peoples' wellbeing and prosperity and inspires production, exchange, distribution and investments in public goods to fairly satisfy them. Ironically, little energy has been spent to perk up productivity of the real economy — agricultural and industrial sectors ensuring sane distribution of livelihood means. Political order regulates the competing interests of diverse groups, subdues the risks of social turmoil, minimises passion of leaders to hurl indictment against each other for holding dissimilar opinions, enables adversarial groups to compromise, engages in wise debate and boosts trust-generating public institutions of society.

One basic source of Nepal's political instability after every political change is that each constitution is drafted on the basis of the power equation or balance of power of dominant political actors of the nation and their ensuing monopoly of the political process afterwards, not on the basic values of constitutionalism and the wisdom of sound institutional checks and balances of power. The constitution became a contested site when power balance altered, dithering ownership of it from within. The other is abysmal pretense about reformist promises articulated in the constitution and party programmes. Political change promised a good life for ordinary Nepalis but ended in a tormenting riff-raff.

The third is an imbalance between leaders' unbounded passion for power and the imperative to unchain those oppressed by poverty. The optimal satisfaction of the basic needs of multitudes can secure the stability of the new political order. The sprawling of social anomie and multiple sites of resistance are teaming up now against the establishment for countless reasons. The fourth is the politics of the blown-up identity division of Nepalis and creation of their inclusive national commissions. It made the constitution the document of a welter of contradictions, not a pull of a single rope of national unity able to convert diverse interests into the actionable equal rights of people for a common life nourished by a democracy of trust, transparency and accountability.

The nascent popular demands for justice and equal dignity mark a revolt against their abject condition of living created by unbridled vices of poverty, joblessness, viciousness of rent-seeking groups, pervasive factionalism, political fragmentation and a string of fraud and corruption scandals, oiling the cog of machine politics. The drain of resources has raised the cost of living and dried up its economic surplus for investment. Tax base of Nepali state is insufficient to sustain and finance its self-sufficiency to stand autonomous of interest groups and sovereign to formulate independent foreign policies, keep social discipline and rally the loyalty of people. Only remittance seems to be a source of sustenance and stabiliser of the external economic front. Out of Nepal's vital potentials -- demographic dividends, hydropower and tourism, only the first one is harnessed despite its sobbing social and economic costs.

Resetting the power of constitutional organs and enabling them to perform impersonally can revitalise the equilibrium of the polity and execute the rule of law in the entire society. It can free the state institutions from political patronage, stabilise its independent source of authority, counter the lurking danger of the institutionalisation of client's power and drive sustainable progress. Policy sovereignty is a key to democracy. Yet, the establishment keeps its clout through a grip on parties, business, police, admin and a host of public institutions and influences a few media while edging to Anglosphere for its neoliberal affinity. A firm political order entails a balance in the jerky ties of neighbours to fulfill its desire of sovereignty. It foils the fallout of geopolitics, operating in democracy-free enclave and hones national interests.

Nepali leaders, blinkered by their own prejudice and learning gap, suffer from a siege mentality. The common feudal passion for life-long party and government leadership, instinct for a syndicated regime and demonisation of opponents deprive the vigor of its political order donned by democracy. Only the fear of common rivals and incentive of power sharing have united the establishment comprising Nepali Congress, CPN-UML and CPN – Maoist Centre. But it has uncommon faults. It has neither created harmony of interests among themselves, nor mollified the heap of grievances, not even nourished stable governance.

> The ascent of political leaders with the temptation of perks and payment has monetised Nepali politics, bloated its financial and bureaucratic costs and reduced its traditional ethos of volunteerism and service orientation.

Its political legitimacy derived from the fusion of bumping urban agitation and roaring rural violence and majoritarian rule has hatched crossbreed political culture strong enough to hold grip in power but weak to address public needs and defy the spirits of political discontents of the new forces engaged in offensive politics in both the parliament and the public sphere. They spark the redolence of political life with a strongly issue-oriented tone and howl to abolish the whiff of vices of politics, business and bureaucracy. It is hard to drag them into conformity to the new political order without structural reforms.

The ascent of political leaders with the temptation of perks and payment has monetised Nepali politics, bloated its financial and bureaucratic costs and reduced its traditional ethos of volunteerism and service orientation. Majority of Nepalis are, therefore, vegetating under the necessity to fulfill their basic needs if not constitutional rights. The revolutionary change in the nation has a brisk start full of hope but it shuddered to revolutionise production, distribution and exchange for macroeconomic stability to salvage the nation from the crushing debris of deficits, debts, dependence and doldrums on policy matters. The awful disconnect between living conditions and democratic aspiration has turned the weaker Nepalis into the losers of the political game without any stake on unequal peace.

Corrective and distributive justice, right to work and ownership in the means of production can enhance the material basis of liberty if realised. Livelihood guarantee is vital for Nepali constitution to create a rational political order in society accepted by all people and those outside the political establishment. Likewise, enculturation, education and political socialisation are the key subjective requirements to enable people to shape common ground, common source of judgment and live peacefully by cooperating with others on shared order. Nepali polity is slowly losing its stable equilibrium. Its constitution grants disproportional rights and few duties to citizens. It has incubated rights-based assertion and organisations and enabled aspiration-driven political parties to control all spheres of life. Balancing the language of rights with duties can shore up a rational order in society.

Its traditional sources of political order maintained through the reasons of the state to abolish the state of nature, create a civic order, strong leadership virtues, tradition, religion, rituals, discipline and administrative regulation are eroding fast while the new traits of individualism, personal skills, abilities and leadership cult, law and social contract are not amply attuned to foster public good to stitch people to this political order and their legendary bond with the land. The sovereignty of the state to shape foreign policy is also fading. The Nepali state is heavily dependent on outside forces for power, resources and legitimacy while societal actors are competing with it and building solidarity abroad for their selfish interests, not shoring up common interests vital for the political order. Its outcome is losing leverage to leap ahead.

Old golden mean

The old golden mean of Nepali politics, the middle path, that sought to reduce the vices of many ideologies through welfare state, civic nationalism and Nepalisation show the signs of sterility. The establishment is struggling to fend off three currents in Nepali politics -- radicalism, populism and conservatism to optimise their and other sub-systems' differing values, interests, ideologies, identities and preferences into the constitutional system. It can manage the risk of disorder spilling into the public sphere if it puts people before partisan politics. The growth of political culture of constitutional order demands matching acculturation to the changes in the values, learning, habits and institutional adaptation, not impunity and scarcity.

Only a shared political culture of democracy can reduce the aspect of coercion and manage the thieves of state and power brokers in Nepali society. Building public trust in the new political order entails the knack of leadership to timely respond to the waves of innovation, knowledge, science and social change. It also needs flexible adjustment of the constitution and institutions of the polity to meet the imperative of modernisation and open political processes that accept and tolerate orderly sustainable progress driven by the people's experience of life, needs and rights and satisfy them.

(Former Reader at the Department of Political Science, TU, Dahal writes on political and social issues.)

Night Rider Chronicles

AASHISH MISHRA

If, like the scribe, you work irregular hours and have found yourself straddling a motorcycle beneath the celestial spotlight of the moon, you know that riding in Kathmandu at night isn't just about reaching your destination – it is about soaking up the experience and seeing just how different the city gets after the sun sets.

One of the first things you notice when you hit the road at night is just how much respect people lose for their lives. Pedestrians are much too willing to jump in front of vehicles at random locations. Zebra crossing, what are those? Overhead bridges? Why take the high road when I can pirouette through traffic? Street-level superheroes don't take no safety precautions.

Motorists, too, appear determined to remind you that your time on this green Earth is limited and that your pride and ego are hollow in the face of ever-lingering death.

The two- and four-wheeled chariots plying the night asphalt are oblivious to your existence but committed to emphasising their own. You are but an insignificant insect in front of the mighty gods who were born to rule the roads. They are generous enough to award you the privilege of navigating the thoroughfare during the day, but at night, it's their time to play.

Night-time riding also introduces you to the fascinating world of shadows, or rather, takes you into their Stygian depths. Suddenly, every patch of darkness becomes a potential adversary. A bush on the footpath appears as a monster waiting to lunge and a harmless pothole turns into a sinister creature seeking to devour. Buildings suddenly develop frightening faces and every movement seems to threaten your existence.

Headlights provide a small comfort, but they are no match for the menace the umbral entities unleash upon your psyche. At the end of your journey, you can scarcely fathom the incredulity that you yet persist among the living.

But if shadowy terrors don't get you, dogs sure will. Man's best friend by day, bloodthirsty beasts by night, they lie lurking, eager to pounce on innocent motorcyclists who happen to drive by them. And dogs, let this writer tell you, are judgemental animals. They seldom bark at expensive cars and they often let Harley Davidsons and Ducatis pass without interruptions. But for other two-wheelers, well let's just say that God better be on your side.

Those who regularly drive through alleys after dark know the nuisance of canines all too well. Those who stay on main roads though face another rigmarole – the DUI checks. DUIs, or MaPaSe as they are known in Nepali, are a much needed but highly underappreciated measure for road safety. But one can't help but think there has to be a better way to check for drunk drivers than shoving plastic implements into one's mouth. The same breathalyser used again and again on multiple people; the traffic police may as well ask us to French kiss the rider next to us.

As the machine is brought uncomfortably close to your lips, you see the droplets of spit the previous blower so generously left behind and you begin to regret every decision you made that brought you to this point in life.

Perhaps this was what your sister meant when she shared that random photo on Instagram with the caption "Random photo or have a bad 2024." Oh, if only you hadn't ignored that! And as you're thinking all this, you realise you're already tasting the remnants of someone's questionable life choices.

In the end, after you've defeated the road and begin approaching your abode, you find there is one last hurdle to overcome – the need to ride into a residential area after everyone has gone to sleep. Suddenly the purring of your motorcycle engine becomes a roar that quakes everyone awake. You see the lights turning on and hear whispers of people cursing under their breath. One person dares open his window and before he has even uttered a word, you feel the need to explain yourself, "I am not a drug dealer!"

The guy responds, "I just poked my head out to spit out my tobacco." Ew, he hawks out a black tar loogie from his facial orifice.

"My good sir, you are a disgusting individual," you say, "But please rest assured – and spread the word – that this gentleman you see before you does not deal in pills."

And as you roll up to your doorstep and dismount, you cannot help but feel a sense of accomplishment. You conquered the night and shall live to see another sunrise.

You open your door and go in, to find an unmade bed and dishes still in the sink from the morning. You remember that you were lazy and now have at least 11 things to do before you can embrace sleep. Oh well.

Transforming Mental Health For All



Jhabindra Bhandari

In the changing world, mental health is becoming more complex, but critically important to everyone, everywhere. Drawing on the latest evidence available, it is understandably clear that mental health needs and responses are still inadequate, and insufficiently integrated into public health systems. From the people's voiced experiences, it reveals that mental health care requires socio-political and cultural efforts to value the urgency of mental health conditions, reshape environments and strengthen health systems in a comprehensive approach.

Because of poor mental health, millions of people around the world still suffer in silence. Unfortunately, they experience human rights violations, and are adversely affected in their daily lives. In most of the countries, the mental health conditions are highly prevalent, but the needed care and services are poorly experienced. Evidence suggests that about one in eight people in the world live with a mental disorder. Reportedly, the prevalence of mental health disorder varies with age and sex.

Social exclusion

Again, the experiences of people with poor mental health conditions and their stories of the suffering, stigma, and social exclusion show that we need to create an enabling environment to ensure the critical provision of adequate care and support for the people with mental health conditions at large. A recent WHO report mentions that suicide is a major cause of death among young people. There may be 20 suicide attempts to every one death globally, and yet suicide accounts for more than one in every 100 deaths. There is increasing evidence that transforming mental health essentially requires multi-sectoral promotion and prevention for all. Therefore, reshaping the determinants of mental health requires actions beyond health sector. Moreover, cost-effective promotion and prevention interventions need to consider individual, social and structural determinants of mental health.

From the service point of view, there is increasing focus on strengthening community-based care for all. By shifting the locus of care for severe mental health conditions away from psychiatric hospitals towards community-based mental health services, the services are becoming more accessible and acceptable than institutional care. Most importantly, these are delivering better outcomes for people with mental health conditions.

Social protection initiatives are crucial to enable people with mental health conditions, achieve their recovery goals and live a more satisfying and meaningful life. For example, people living with HIV or TB require specific mental health services and care in health and communities. In addition, adolescents and young people are highly vulnerable to mental health issues and psychoactive drug use. Older people, including those living with HIV, are more likely to experience mental health and neurocognitive impairment, as well as social isolation, due to decreased social participation and engagement. Similarly, people affected by TB have a higher risk of mental health conditions, which can negatively impact TB treatment outcomes, health-related quality of life and other health and social outcomes.

According to a national mental health survey report – 2020, there are interesting facts about the situation of mental health in Nepal. The prevalence of mental disorder among adolescents is 5.2 per cent. Similarly, the prevalence of current suicidal thoughts among adolescents is 3.9 per cent while that of lifetime suicidal attempt is 0.7 per cent. Among the adult participants, 10 per cent had any mental disorder in their lifetime, and 4.3 percent currently has any mental disorder.

> Social protection initiatives are crucial to enable people with mental health conditions, achieve their recovery goals and live a more satisfying and meaningful life.

Like many other countries in Asia, Nepal has given a high priority for mental health needs and services for all. More importantly, mental health is included in the list of basic health services. Further, public health service regulations have expanded the type of mental health services to be included in basic health services and emergency health service package. The national health policy-2019 also articulates the needs for mental health services to be sufficiently integrated into health systems. This also links to government's strong commitment for achieving Universal Health Coverage (UHC) and health related Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs).

Equitable access

Though mental health is one of the priority agenda in health policy and strategic action plan, there is an emerging need for effective implementation of national mental health strategy and action plan -2020 at local level. The mental health strategy and action plan addresses integration of mental health in primary care and suggests the critical need to strengthen mental health services at the secondary health care level. Some of the implementation challenges for effective implementation of the mental health strategy and action plan include inadequate trained human resources for mental health, limited financial investments, persistent stigma and discrimination, lack of wider public awareness and social advocacy for integrated response to mental health conditions. In order to ensure equitable access to quality mental health for all, provision of participatory, inclusive and rights-based mental health care is critically needed in the federal context.

While mental health needs of people affected by disasters and disease outbreaks are widely recognised, the capacity enhancement of local governments is crucial in integrating mental health services in local health policies, strategies and plans. Accumulative lessons from the disaster and pandemics such as COVID-19 have shown increasing needs of mental health services for people's healthy and secured lives. As we know by now, mental health has intrinsic and instrumental value, helping us to connect, function, cope and thrive in different socio-cultural contexts. Undoubtedly, mental health should be a priority development agenda for all. The vicious cycle between poverty and mental ill-health exacerbates the mental health conditions. Strengthening mental health care enhances the capacity of service providers to deliver person-centred and human rights-based care by effectively engaging people with their lived experiences, needs and choices.

(Bhandari is a health policy analyst.)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

January 20, 1974

USSR To Help India To Make Satellite

Delhi, Jan 19: Soviet scientists and specialists jointly with Indian colleagues work to create the first Indian artificial earth's satellite.

NOTICE TO CONTRIBUTORS

TRN welcomes articles, letters and comments from our valued readers and contributors.
Please email your contributions to:

trnfeatures@hotmail.com
trnfeatures@gmail.com

Or send them to
P.O. Box 23, Kathmandu, Nepal

READER'S MAIL

Saving People From Cold Wave

Concerning the news story "*Cold wave affects life across Tarai*," published in your prestigious daily recently, the entire plains in Nepal and India stretching to Delhi and NCR are under the spell of cold weather, dense fog and poor visibility.

Life in some Nordic countries has frozen in as much as -40 degrees Celcius. Comparatively, the former Shangri-La Valley of Kathmandu has the best winter month of Pousa in living memory.

We hope it will stay like this for 15-20 days when winter begins its retreat.

As many parts of Western Europe face climate wrath, we have no such problem which might surprise the UNSG, who came to take stock of the effects of the climate fiend, the growing emission of carbon clouds, on the Himalayas from Karakoram to Myanmar.

We could fend off the carbon threat



by taking local diagnoses such as not destroying the Chure range, mid, lower and upper Himalayas and reducing footfall, among other prognosis.

Manohar Shrestha
Kathmandu

TAILPIECE

One day St. Peter saw a street gang walking up to the Pearly Gates.

St. Peter ran to God and said, "God, there are some low-life street gang members at the Gates. What do I do?"

God relied, "Just do what you normally do with that type. Redirect them."

St. Peter went back to carry out the order, but he suddenly came running back and yelling, "God, God, they're gone! They're gone!"

"The street gang?"

"No, the Pearly Gates!"

NATO holds its biggest exercises in decades next week

AP
Brussels, Jan. 19



PHOTO: AP
Chair of the NATO Military Committee Admiral Rob Bauer, center, Supreme Allied Commander Europe, General Christopher Cavoli, left, and Supreme Allied Commander Transformation General Chris Badia prepare to address a media conference at NATO headquarters in Brussels, Thursday, Jan. 18, 2024.

NATO will launch its biggest military exercises in decades next week with around 90,000 personnel set to take part in months of drills aimed at showing the alliance can defend all of its territory up to its border with Russia, top officers said Thursday.

The exercises come as Russia's war on Ukraine bogs down. NATO as an organization is not directly involved in the conflict, except to supply Kyiv with non-lethal support, although many member countries send weapons and ammunition individually or in groups, and provide military training.

In the months before President Vladimir Putin ordered Russian troops into Ukraine in February 2022, NATO began beefing up security on its eastern flank with Russia and Ukraine. It's the alliance's biggest buildup since the Cold War. The war games are meant to deter Russia from targeting a member country.

The exercises – dubbed Steadfast Defender 24 – "will show that NATO can conduct and sustain complex multi-domain operations over several months, across thousands of kilometers (miles), from the High North to Central and Eastern Europe, and in any condition," the 31-nation organization said.

Troops will be moving to and through Europe until the end of May in what NATO describes as "a simulated emerging conflict scenario with a near-peer adversary." Under NATO's new defense plans, its chief adversaries are Russia and terrorist organizations.

"The alliance will demonstrate its ability to reinforce the Euro-Atlantic area via transatlantic movement of forces from North America," NATO's Supreme Allied Commander, U.S. General Christopher Cavoli, told reporters. Cavoli said it will demonstrate "our unity, our strength, and our determination to protect each other."

The chair of the NATO Military Committee, Admiral Rob Bauer, said that it's "a record number of troops that we can bring to bear and have an exercise within that size, across the alliance, across the ocean from the U.S. to Europe."

Bauer described it as "a big change" compared to troop numbers exercising just a year ago. Sweden, which is expected to join NATO this year, will also take part.

US forces strike Houthi sites in Yemen

AP
Washington, Jan. 19



PHOTO: AP
President Joe Biden speaks to the media before boarding Marine One on the South Lawn of the White House, Thursday, Jan. 18, 2024, in Washington.

U.S. forces on Thursday conducted a fifth strike against Iranian-backed Houthi rebel military sites in Yemen as President Joe Biden acknowledged that the American and British bombardment had yet to stop the militants' attacks on vessels in the Red Sea that have disrupted global shipping.

The latest strikes destroyed two Houthi anti-ship missiles that "were aimed into the southern Red Sea and prepared to launch," U.S. Central Command said in a statement posted to X, formerly known as Twitter. They were conducted by Navy F/A-18 fighter aircraft, the Pentagon said.

Biden said the U.S. would continue the strikes, even though so far they have not stopped the Houthis from continuing to harass commercial and military vessels.

"When you say working, are they stopping the Houthis, no. Are they going to continue, yes," Biden said in an exchange with reporters before departing the White House for a domestic policy speech in North Carolina.

Hours after Biden spoke, Houthi Brig. Gen. Yahya Saree said in a prerecorded statement that its forces had carried out another missile attack against the Marshall Islands-flagged, U.S.-owned cargo ship Chem Ranger. Saree said the attack took place in the Gulf of Aden, the waters just south of Yemen.

That attack did not affect the ship, U.S. Central Command said in a statement late Thursday. "The crew observed the missiles impact the water near the ship," there were no reported injuries or damage and the ship continued on its way, Central Command said.

The continued harassment of the ships has driven the U.S. and international partners to take extraordinary steps to defend them through a joint mission named Operation Prosperity Guardian, in which the consortium is trying to create a protective umbrella for the vessels by intercepting any missiles or drones that target them. It has also led the U.S. and British militaries to take measures to knock out missile sites, radars and air defense systems to try to tamp down the Houthis' ability to attack.

On Wednesday the U.S. military fired another wave of ship- and submarine-launch missile strikes against 14 Houthi-controlled sites. That same day, the administration put the Houthis back on its list of specially designated global terrorists. The sanctions that come with the formal designation are meant to sever violent extremist groups from their sources of financing, while also allowing vital humanitarian aid to continue flowing to impoverished Yemenis.

"These strikes will continue for as long as they need to continue," National Security Council spokesman John Kirby said Thursday, adding, "I'm not going to telegraph punches one way or another."

NKorea says it tested a nuclear-capable underwater drone

AP
South Korea, Jan. 19

North Korea said Friday it has tested a nuclear-capable underwater attack drone in response to a combined naval exercise by South Korea, the United States and Japan this week, as it continues to blame its rivals for raising tensions in the region.

The test of the drone, purportedly designed to destroy naval vessels and ports, came days after North Korean leader Kim Jong Un declared he is scrapping his country's long-standing goal of a peaceful reunification with South Korea and that his country will rewrite its constitution to define South Korea as its most hostile foreign adversary.

Tensions on the Korean Peninsula have risen to their highest point in years, with Kim accelerating his weapons testing and threatening nuclear conflict.

The United States and its Asian allies have responded by strengthening their combined military exercises, which Kim calls rehearsals for an invasion.

The underwater drone, which North Korea said it first tested last year, is among a broad range of weapon systems demonstrated in recent years as Kim expands his arsenal of nuclear-capable weapons. South Korea's military says North Korea has exaggerated the capabilities of the drone.

North Korea's military said it conducted the test in the country's eastern waters in response to a naval drill by the U.S., South Korea and Japan which ended Wednesday in waters south of Jeju island. It did not say when the test occurred.

"Our army's underwater nuke-based countering posture is being further rounded off and its various maritime and underwater responsive actions will continue to deter the hostile military maneuvers of the navies of the U.S. and its allies," North Korea's Defense Ministry said in a statement.

North Korea in recent months has tested various missile systems designed to target the United States and its Asian allies, and announced an escalatory nuclear doctrine that authorizes the military to conduct preemptive nuclear strikes if North Korea's leadership is under threat.

North Korea conducted its first ballistic missile test of 2024 on Sunday. State media described it as a new solid-fuel, intermediate-range missile tipped with a hypersonic warhead, likely intended to target U.S. military bases in Guam and Japan.

Pakistan holds emergency security meeting

AFP
Pakistan, Jan. 19

Pakistan's Prime Minister will hold an emergency security meeting on Friday with military and intelligence chiefs after trading deadly air strikes with Iran on militant targets this week.

The rare military actions in the porous border region of Baluchistan -- shared between the two countries -- has further stoked regional tensions already enflamed by the Israel-Hamas war.

Iran carried out a missile and drone attack on what it called "terrorist" targets in Pakistan on Tuesday night, with Pakistan in turn striking militant targets inside Iran on Thursday.

The United Nations and United States have appealed for restraint, while China has offered to mediate between the two countries.

"The Prime Minister has summoned a meeting of the National Security Committee set to take place today," a spokesperson in his office told AFP.

An Islamabad security official said the Chief of Army Staff and head of the intelligence services will attend the mid-afternoon meeting.

Pakistan's caretaker leader Anwar-ul-Haq Kakar cut short his visit to the World Economic Forum in Davos, Switzerland following the strikes.

His caretaker government is leading Pakistan into general elections which are just three weeks away and have been marred by allegations of pre-poll rigging.

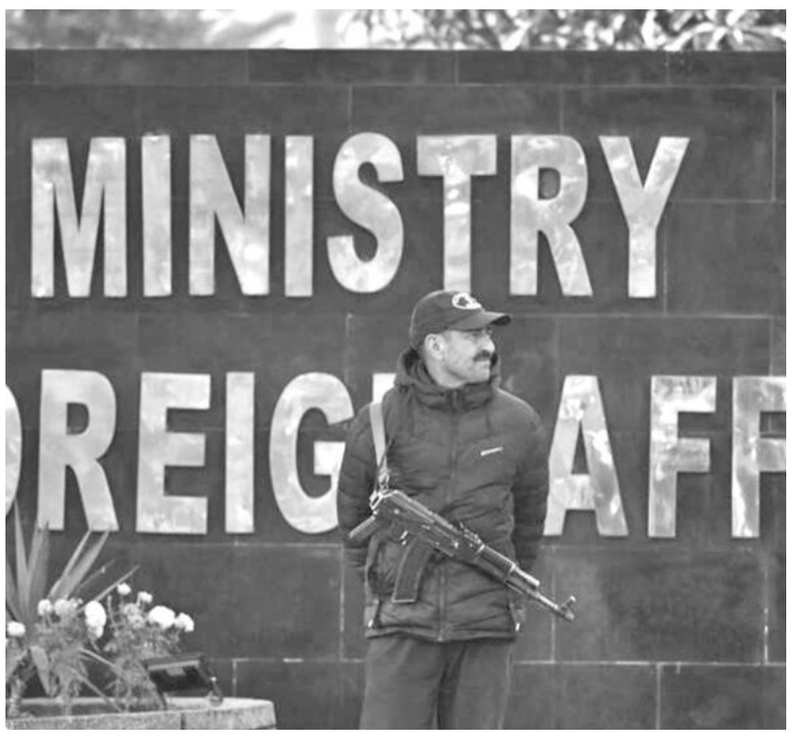


PHOTO: AFP
A Pakistani police officer stands guard outside the Ministry of Foreign Affairs in Islamabad on January 18, 2024.

PRISM

Escaped pig found playing in snow

Kentucky: A pig escaped from a trailer in a Kentucky city and enjoyed some time playing in the snow before being rounded up by police.

The Richmond Police Department said in an Instagram post that the pig escaped from a trailer in Richmond and «spent some time enjoying the winter weather and recent snowfall.»

"Kids aren't the only ones who love a snow day," the post said.

Police shared photos of the pig with its snout covered in snow as it played near a gas station.

"The pig has since been reunited with its owner, and gladly agreed to pose for a picture with some of the officers who helped with its safe return," police wrote.

Loose horse rounded up on highway

Tennessee: Sheriff's deputies in Tennessee came to the rescue when an escaped horse was spotted galloping on the highway.

The Hamilton County Sheriff's Office said deputies responded Tuesday when a loose horse was spotted on Highway 27.

A dashcam video shows Deputy Ricardo Santiago driving behind the horse in the northbound lanes to keep the wandering equine safe from traffic. Santiago follows the horse at a slow speed until a trailer arrives on the scene.

The horse was safely returned to its owner. "Just another day in the life of a HCSO deputy. We are always ready to serve, even when it comes to our four-legged citizens," the sheriff's office said in a Facebook post.

(AP)

TODAY IN HISTORY

1576 – The Mexican city of León is founded by order of the viceroy Don Martín Enríquez de Almanza.
1841 – Hong Kong Island is occupied by the British during the First Opium War.
1887 – The United States Senate allows the Navy to lease Pearl Harbor as a naval base.
1921 – The first Constitution of Turkey is adopted, making fundamental changes in the source and exercise of sovereignty by consecrating the principle of national sovereignty.
1945 – World War II: Germany begins the evacuation of 1.8 million people from East Prussia, a task which will take nearly two months.
1945 – World War II: Germany begins the evacuation of 1.8 million people from East Prussia, a task which will take nearly two months.
2021 – Joe Biden is inaugurated as the 46th President of the United States of America.

Largest deep-sea coral reef to date is mapped

AP
Washington, Jan. 19

Scientists have mapped the largest coral reef deep in the ocean, stretching hundreds of miles off the U.S. Atlantic coast.

While researchers have known since the 1960s that some coral were present off the Atlantic, the reef's size remained a mystery until new underwater mapping technology made it possible to construct 3D images of the ocean floor.

The largest yet known deep coral reef "has been right under our noses, waiting to be discovered," said Derek Sowers, an oceanographer at the nonprofit Ocean Exploration Trust.

Sowers and other scientists, including several at the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration, recently published maps of the reef in the journal Geomatics.

The reef extends for about 310 miles (499 kilometers) from Florida to South Carolina and at some points reaches 68 miles (109 kilometers) wide. The total area is nearly three times the size of Yellowstone National Park.



PHOTO: AP
In this image provided by NOAA Ocean Exploration, an alfonsino fish swims above a thicket of Lophelia pertusa coral during a dive on a cold water coral mound in the center of the Blake Plateau off the southeastern coast of the U.S., in June 2019. In January 2024.

"It's eye-opening — it's breathtaking in scale," said Stuart Sandin, a marine biologist at the Scripps Institution of Oceanography, who was not involved in the study.

The reef was found at depths ranging from 655 feet to 3,280 feet (200 meters to 1,000 meters), where sunlight doesn't penetrate. Unlike tropical coral reefs, where photosynthesis is important for growth, coral this far down must filter food particles out of the water for energy.

Deep coral reefs provide habitat for sharks, swordfish, sea stars, octopus, shrimp and many other kinds of fish, the scientists said.

Tropical reefs are better known to scientists — and snorkelers -- because they're more accessible. The world's largest tropical coral reef system, the Great Barrier Reef in Australia, stretches for about 1,430 miles (2,301 kilometers).

Sowers said it's possible that larger deep-sea reefs will be discovered in the future since only about 75% of the world's ocean floor has been mapped in high-resolution. Only 50% of U.S. offshore waters have been mapped. Maps of the ocean floor are created using high-resolution sonar devices carried on ships.

Deep reefs cover more of the ocean floor than tropical reefs. Both kinds of habitat are susceptible to similar risks, including climate change and disturbance from oil and gas drilling, said Erik Cordes, a marine biologist at Temple University and co-author of the new study.



PHOTO: SUJAN GURUNG/TRN

A flyover being constructed in Gwarko, Lalitpur.

PM meets Nepalis in Uganda

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 19

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda', who reached Uganda on Thursday to participate in the 19th summit of the Non-Aligned Movement (NAM), met with Nepalis living in Yuganda the same day.

At the meeting, PM Prachanda informed that this was his first visit to the African nation and expressed happiness at being able to interact with Nepalis there.

Noting the issues raised by those gathered, the Prime Minister said that he was working to solve problems troubling Nepalis abroad.

"I recently took an important decision for those travelling on visit visas. And some time ago, I also called all Nepali ambassadors abroad to discuss solutions to migration problems," he said.

He shared his belief that Nepal would not move forward until the problems of Nepalis living abroad were addressed.

Also speaking on the occasion, Minister for Foreign Affairs NP Saud reminded the Nepali community that their activities would reflect on the country and asked them to help improve the nation's image.

Meanwhile, Rama Aryal, president of the Non-Resident Nepali Association's Uganda chapter, said that the Nepalis in Yuganda were elated at getting to meet their Prime Minister.

Ramesh Kandel, patron of the Uganda chapter, informed that there were over 350 Nepal nationals currently living in the East African country.

11% food packaging samples found to contain harmful substance

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 19

A recent worldwide study led by the International Pollutants Elimination Network (IPEN) and joined by the Center for Public Health and Environmental Development (CEPHED) in Nepal sheds light on the widespread presence of harmful per-and poly-fluoroalkyl substances (PFAS), often known as Forever Chemicals, in various food packaging materials.

PFAS, found in items like clothing, food packaging, and water, have been linked to fertility issues, fetal development problems, and disruptions in thyroid hormone function. The research, conducted across 17 countries including India, Mexico, and Nepal, focused on 233 paper cardboard and plant-based packaging items from food stores and fast-food restaurants.

According to a press statement issued by CEPHED, using advanced testing methods, the study revealed that 54 per cent of the 119 samples contained PFAS. Disturbingly, 11.1 per cent of Nepali samples were positive for PFAS, with one plate from Bhatbhateni Super Market containing over three times the EU limits.

Of concern were plant-based moulded fiber products, like bowls and plates, which consistently showed the highest PFAS concentrations. Fast-food wrappers, microwave popcorn bags, and recycled paper packaging for non-greasy meals were also flagged as common sources of contamination.

Ram Charitra Sah, Executive Director and Environment Scientist at CEPHED, expressed worry over the findings, calling for urgent action against PFAS-treated packaging materials. The study highlighted the risk of continuous exposure to PFAS through recycling treated paper.

Advocating for swift action, the study urged governments, regulatory bodies, and businesses to stop using PFAS-treated food packaging items.

Sah emphasized the need for robust regulations, standards, and widespread consumer education, particularly targeting fast-food enthusiasts and the youth who frequently consume these products.

As concerns rise globally about PFAS in everyday items, collective efforts are essential to address the health risks associated with these persistent and harmful chemicals, the statement said.

Chinese envoy, LDT Vice Chair hold meeting

BY LAXMAN PAUDEL
Bhairahawa, Jan. 19

Dr. Lama told the Chinese envoy that the LDT was preparing to complete the implementation of the master plan.

Ambassador of China to Nepal Chen Song and Vice Chairman of the Lumbini Development Trust (LDT) Dr. Lharkyal Lama (Khenpo Chimed) met at Lumbini's Chinese Monastery on Thursday.

According to Lama, the two discussed the implementation of the Lumbini Master Plan, the creation of a favourable environment for the Chinese pilgrims and the development and conservation of the Lumbini area.

Dr. Lama told the Chinese envoy that the LDT was preparing to complete the implementation of the master plan. He also said that the Trust was planning to formulate master plans for the development of the Kapilvastu and Ramgram areas.

LDT Member Secretary Sanuraja Shakya, and Executive Board Members Rajesh Shakya and Shyam Rokka were also present at the meeting.

On the same day, the Chinese monastery also organised a milk-rice pudding Prasad distribution programme for the coming Chinese New Year where Lama said that Lumbini was eager to welcome Chinese tourists. He said, "We are awaiting the day we will be able to welcome thousands of Chinese visitors here."

Sujata was a farmer's wife who is said to have fed Lord Gautam Buddha a bowl of pudding, ending his six years of asceticism. The Prasad distribution was also organised to commemorate this.

Also speaking at the programme, Ambassador Song recalled the journey made by Chinese travellers over 1,500 years ago and how the account of their travel helped rediscover Lumbini in the modern era. He further expressed happiness at being able to come to such a holy place as Lumbini.

Song also felt the need for the world to internalise Buddha's message of peace and non-violence.

Local bodies of Bajura preparing for winter session



PHOTO: SHER BAHADUR SARKI/TRN

Himali Rural Municipality's 13th Rural Municipal Assembly being held on Thursday.

BY SHER BAHADUR SARKI
Bajura, Jan. 19

The 9 local bodies of Bajura district are busy convening the winter session. The preparations are underway to discuss the status of development, budget expenditure report, achievement of programmes, problems while working, people's complaints, upcoming budget and new policy laws.

Swamikartik, Jaganath, Budhinanda, Badimalika, Gaumul, Budiganga and Khaptad Chhededaha Municipalities and Rural Municipalities of the Bajura district are convening their winter session to review the works done in the past year, to bring about changes in the budget and make some more laws required by the local government.

It is informed that Triveni Municipality of Bajura conducted its session from January 14 to 16. The winter session has given priority to education, health, roads, drinking water, earthquake-affected families, tourism and agriculture including other contemporary issues, said Chiranjibi Shah, chief administrative officer of Triveni Municipality.

Similarly, the Himali Rural Municipality has also started its winter session from Thursday. The Rural Municipality has begun its 13th Rural Municipal Assembly with the slogan of "Health, Education, Agriculture, Herbs, Tourism, Water Resources and Infrastructure, Industrialization, Good Governance, and Poverty Alleviation as a Prosperous Himalayan Basis".

Raj Bahadur Bhandari, Chief Administrative Officer of Himali Rural Municipality said that the Code of Conduct for the Prevention of Sexual Abuse-2080 and the Economic Amendment Procedure were discussed in the session.

East and West coasts prepare for new rounds of snow and ice as deadly storms pound US

AP
Portland, Jan. 19

Storms that have turned roads into icy death traps, frozen people to death from Oregon to Tennessee and even sent a plane skidding off a taxiway were expected to sock both coasts with another round of weather chaos on Friday.

New York City — which only on Tuesday saw its first significant snow in more than two years — was in the headlights as the National Weather Service laid out warnings of slightly more than 2 inches (5 centimeters) of snow through Friday in the metropolitan area, with New Jersey and Pennsylvania also getting snow.

On Thursday, an American Airlines plane slid off a snowy taxiway in Rochester, New York, after a flight from Philadelphia. No injuries were reported.

On the West Coast, Oregon's governor declared a statewide emergency Thursday night after requests for aid from multiple counties "as they enter the sixth day of severe impacts" from weather marked by freezing rain.

Thousands of residents have been without power since Saturday in parts of Oregon's Willamette Valley after an ice storm caused extensive damage.

"We lost power on Saturday, and we were told yesterday that it would be over two weeks before it's back on," said Jamie Kenworthy, a real estate broker in Jasper in Lane County.

In the past two weeks, storms have blasted much of the U.S. with rain, snow, wind and frigid temperatures, snarling traffic and air travel and causing at least 45 deaths.



PHOTO: AP

Snow is cleared from the bike lane and sidewalk along Third Avenue near the Linn County Courthouse in Cedar Rapids, Iowa, on Wednesday, Jan. 17.

That included three people electrocuted Wednesday by a downed power line in Portland, Oregon. A man trying to get out of a parked car covered by the line died with a baby in his arms after slipping on the icy driveway and hitting the live wire. The baby survived.

His pregnant 21-year-old girlfriend and her 15-year-old brother died when they tried to help. Their father, Ronald Briggs, told KGW-TV that he helplessly watched their deaths.

"I have six kids. I lost two of them in one day," he said.

Crews had made steady progress restoring power to tens of thousands of customers in Oregon after back-to-back storms, but by Friday morning more than 107,000 were without electricity, according to poweroutage.us.

Portland Public Schools canceled classes for the fourth straight day amid concerns about icy roads and water damage to buildings, and state offices in Portland were also ordered closed Friday.

In Washington, D.C., snow fell softly and the streets around the U.S. Capitol were silent. Schools closed again for the second time in a week and the government was on a two-hour delay. President Joe Biden still planned to host mayors from around the country on Friday, though, and was still heading to his Delaware beach home for the weekend. The weather service expected 4 to 6 inches (10 to 15 centimeters) in the region.

Schools were also closed due to weather conditions Friday in many counties in Maryland, northern Virginia and West Virginia, where the governor declared a state of emergency on Thursday.

Bitter weather continued in the South, where a new layer of ice formed over parts of Tennessee on Thursday — part of a broader bout of cold sweeping the country.

Authorities blamed at least 14 deaths in Tennessee on the system, which dumped more than 9 inches (22.8 centimeters) of snow since Sunday on parts of Nashville, a city that rarely see such accumulations.

Temperatures also plunged below zero (minus 17.7 Celsius) in parts of the state, creating the largest power demand ever across the seven states served by the Tennessee Valley Authority.

The dead included a box truck driver who slid into a tractor-trailer on an interstate, a man who fell through a skylight while cleaning a roof, and a woman who died of hypothermia after being found unresponsive in her home.

Icy roads in Tennessee made travel treacherous Thursday night. In Anderson County outside of Knoxville, the sheriff's department said in a social media post that emergency workers were having a difficult time responding to many crashes amid the worst road conditions in years as their own vehicles were stuck and out of service.

Pangolin in...

Kerawari Rural Municipality in Morang has initiated conservation efforts in collaboration with the local community forest, following the procedures outlined in the year 2080 BS concerning pangolin conservation.

According to recent data, pangolins have been identified in 43 districts across Nepal.

Search for foreign investors...

All these committees and working groups are actively working in their respective fields, said the IBN.

In the steering committee meeting held today, the Minister for Industry, Commerce and Supplies, Minister for Energy, Water Resources and Irrigation, Minister for Forest and Environment,

Minister for Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation and Minister for Urban Development, vice-chairman of the National Planning Commission, the Chief Secretary and secretaries of various ministries, deputy governor of Nepal Rastra Bank and representatives of the umbrella organisations of the private sector were present.

Japan's first moon lander is aiming for a very small target

AP
Tokyo, Jan. 19

As Japan's space agency prepares for its first moon landing early Saturday, it's aiming to hit a very small target. The Smart Lander for Investigating Moon, a lightweight spacecraft about the size of a passenger vehicle, is using "pinpoint landing" technology that promises far greater control than any previous moon landing.

While most previous probes have used landing zones some 10 kilometers (6 miles) wide, SLIM is aiming at a target of just 100 meters (330 feet). It's the fruit of two decades of work on precision technology by the Japan Aerospace Exploration Agency, or JAXA. If successful, it would make Japan the fifth country to land on the moon, after the United States, Russia, China and India.

The mission's main goal is to test new landing technology that would allow moon missions to land "where we want to, rather than where it is easy to land," JAXA has said.

FDB starts discussion on proposed Film Act

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 19



The Film Development Board (FDB) has discussed with stakeholders the opinions and suggestions received on the draft bill to amend and unify laws related to films.

The board discussed with representatives of film-related organisations and filmmakers focusing on the issues of demand and address.

Approximately three months ago, the board released a draft, inviting necessary opinions and suggestions.

Based on this draft, all associations advocated for amendments, submitting feedback in writing.

During the discussions, Bhuwan KC, the executive chairman of the board, emphasised the film industry's long-standing efforts to pass a new film act.

He expressed the urgency of achieving consensus among all stakeholders to benefit Nepal's national cinema.

KC highlighted that the draft aimed to safeguard the rights and interests of the film industry, incorporating numerous suggestions and requiring some amendments.

He mentioned the positive stance of the Minister for Communication and Information Technology, ensuring the bill's passage within their tenure.

Bishal Sapkota, the board's member secretary and deputy secretary of the Ministry of Communication and Information Technology, said that the ongoing discussions were not the final ones.

Sapkota acknowledged the potential need for more debates to craft an outstanding law, assuring that the ministry is prepared to pass the bill.

KL Budhathoki, the board's spokesperson and member, emphasised the need for the new law to align with the latest technological advancements and global influences on filmmaking.

He advocated for a law promoting nationality, language, culture, and tourism while fostering freedom of expression and creativity globally.

During the discussion, it was proposed that the law should encompass not only the production, distribution and exhibition aspects but the entire film industry.

Furthermore, suggestions were made to modify the board's structure, have a majority of film experts on the board, cease political appointments of members, establish provincial censor boards for films released provincially, and create an environment conducive to foreign filmmakers producing films in Nepal.

Additionally, recommendations were put forth that when importing foreign films into Nepal, all processes should be handled by the board itself, and the government's investment in art and culture should be transparent.

Actor and producer Deepak Raj Giri emphasised that the Act should strive to grant equal rights to everyone while being cautious to minimise complaints.

Mohan Niraula, President of the Film Artists Association, expressed that if the draft of the bill was passed without alterations, it would be beneficial for the Nepali film industry.

Duet singer Pariyar gaining popularity

BY RADHAKRISHNA DUMRE
Waling, Jan. 19



Folk singer Sita Pariyar is gaining popularity in the folk duet music area.

Her popularity soared even higher after the elders of Lokdohori referred to her as a 'Baglunge Koili'.

Pariyar initially entered the music industry as a folk-duet singer alongside the renowned Prakash Saput.

Currently, she is engaged in shooting 6-7 duet songs per day.

Born in Galkot, Baglung, she has transformed Pokhara into a hub for her career. Despite managing family responsibilities, she travels to various locations, including Kathmandu, to perform her songs.

The festive season has added to her already busy schedule. Pariyar has garnered numerous awards, including the prestigious 'Best Lok Dohori Singer' award at the 'Star Music and Film Awards- 2080' for her song 'Balewama Ghar Chha Panchebaja'.

Nepali song music is expanding globally through digital platforms, and live folk-duet songs are resonating with audiences worldwide.

Pariyar's songs, in particular, are trending on YouTube, contributing to her widespread recognition.

Dedicating 16 years to the industry, Pariyar dominated folk-duet contests in Nepal a decade ago.

She earned the 'Best Dohori Singer' award at the 'National Highlights Nepal Lok Dohori Award – 2070,' and she also won a cash prize of Rs. 50,000 in the largest national open duet competition organised by the Kalyan Sherchan Smriti Pratisthan Nepal in Pokhara two years ago, beating other 47 groups. She also grabbed the award for the 'Best Live Dohori Singer' at the National Gandaki Music Award- 2080' held in Pokhara.

Pariyar has also showcased her talent internationally, serving as a guest artist in a live folk-duet programme abroad, including the 'Teej Dhamaka -2080' organised by Galkot Society Japan. Despite residing in Mofasal, Pariyar remains popular among both new and seasoned duet singers.

Although folk-duet singing may seem entertaining and straightforward, experts emphasise its remarkable complexity.

The ability to capture the audience's hearts in a matter of seconds through a combination of words, music, and voice requires exceptional knowledge, skills, and abilities in folk-duet songs.

'Oppenheimer' and 'Poor Things' lead the race for Britain's BAFTA film awards

AP
London, Jan. 19



Atom-bomb epic "Oppenheimer" leads the race for the British Academy Film Awards, with nominations in 13 categories including best film — eight more than its box-office rival, "Barbie."

Gothic fantasia "Poor Things" received 11 nominations on the list announced Thursday, while historical epic "Killers of the Flower Moon" and Holocaust drama " The Zone of Interest" had nine each.

Other leading contenders include French courtroom drama "Anatomy of a Fall," boarding school comedy "The Holdovers" and Leonard Bernstein biopic "Maestro," with seven nominations each. Grief-flecked love story "All of Us Strangers" was nominated in six categories and class-war dramedy "Saltburn " in five.

" Barbie," one half of 2023's "Barbenheimer" box office juggernaut, also got five nominations, but missed out on nods for best picture and best director.

The winners will be announced at a Feb. 18 ceremony at London's Royal Festival Hall hosted by "Doctor Who" star David Tennant.

The prizes — officially called the EE BAFTA Film Awards — are Britain's equivalent of Hollywood's Academy Awards and will be watched closely for hints of who may win at the Oscars on March 10.

The best film race pits "Oppenheimer" against "Poor Things," "Killers of the Flower Moon," "Anatomy of a Fall" and "The Holdovers."

"Poor Things" is also on the 10-strong list for the separate category of best British film, an eclectic slate that includes "Saltburn," imperial epic "Napoleon," south London romcom "Rye Lane" and chocolatier origin story "Wonka," among others.

The best leading actor nominees are Bradley Cooper for "Maestro," Colman Domingo for "Rustin," Paul Giamatti for "The Holdovers," Barry Keoghan for "Saltburn," Teo Yoo for "Past Lives" and Cillian Murphy for "Oppenheimer."

"Oppenheimer" also received nominations for supporting performers Emily Blunt and Robert Downey Jr., as well as for Christopher Nolan's direction and screenplay.

"I couldn't be happier that the British Academy recognized so many of my collaborators on 'Oppenheimer,' especially Chris Nolan," Murphy said. "Working on the film was an experience I'll never forget."

Taylor Swift leads 2024 iHeartRadio Music Award Noms

AP
Los Angeles, Jan. 19

Taylor Swift leads the 2024 iHeartRadio Music Awards nominations with nine, followed closely by Jelly Roll, SZA, and 21 Savage with eight. Behind them is Olivia Rodrigo, who received seven.

The iHeartRadio Music Awards honor the most played artists of the year on their stations and app.

Fans can vote in several categories including best lyrics, best music video, best fan army, social star award, favorite tour photographer, TikTok bop of the year, favorite tour style and two new fields: favorite on screen and favorite debut album.

Social voting begins today at iHeartRadio.com/awards and will close on March 25 at 11:59 p.m. PDT for all categories.

There are a total of seven new categories this year, from the two aforementioned socially-voted category to pop song of the year, pop artist of the year, K-pop artist of the year, K-pop song of the year and best new K-pop artist.

For top song of the year, Taylor Swift's "Cruel Summer" faces off against Rema and Selena Gomez's Afrobeats banger "Calm Down," Metro Boomin, the Weeknd and 21 Savage's "Creepin'," Dua Lipa's "Dance the Night," Luke Combs' award-winning cover of Tracey Chapman's "Fast Car," Miley Cyrus' "Flowers," SZA's "Kill Bill," Morgan Wallen's "Last Night," Doja Cat's "Paint the Town Red," and Olivia Rodrigo's "vampire."

The 2024 iHeartRadio Music Awards will air live from Dolby Theatre in Los Angeles, Monday, April 1 at 8 p.m. EDT on FOX.

It will also air on iHeartRadio stations across the U.S. and the app.

HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

ARIES: Work smarter, not harder. You may have had a work routine that you felt was serving you until recently, or your responsibilities could be something that you've grown used to over time.

TAURUS: You should soon be able to set down some of your burdens. It could feel like a relief once someone else allows you to break free by shouldering any responsibilities that you've had weighing you down for so long.

GEMINI: An opportunity to find closure is presently near. You may have wondered how another person felt for ages, believed that you didn't get necessary answers regarding a painful time in your past.

CANCER: Peace can be settled between important people in your life. Two people who are close to you may have been at odds, straining your relationships with both of them.

LEO: You can change the way that you treat your soul. Your relationship with yourself might not be as healthy as it needs to be -- you potentially speak to yourself negatively, don't leave time for rest.

VIRGO: You're letting go of being stuck. Up until now, you may have let yourself hang onto negative habits that could be stunting your emotional growth or preventing you from releasing negative memories.

LIBRA: You're done taking orders from people who don't understand you! It's possible that you've allowed others to dictate what you do, think, and say for too long.

SCORPIO: A support system might no longer be supporting you. While it may have felt like this group gave you a safe harbor before, they've potentially changed their tune and aren't willing to be there for you when you need them.

SAGITTARIUS: Stability is possible where there was once none. Perhaps you used to seek out other people's opinions when it came to what you needed in your life, and because of this.

CAPRICORN: Changing the self can be the hardest task of all. You may have recently come to grips with certain aspects of yourself that you want to phase out or behaviors that potentially don't come from a true place within you.

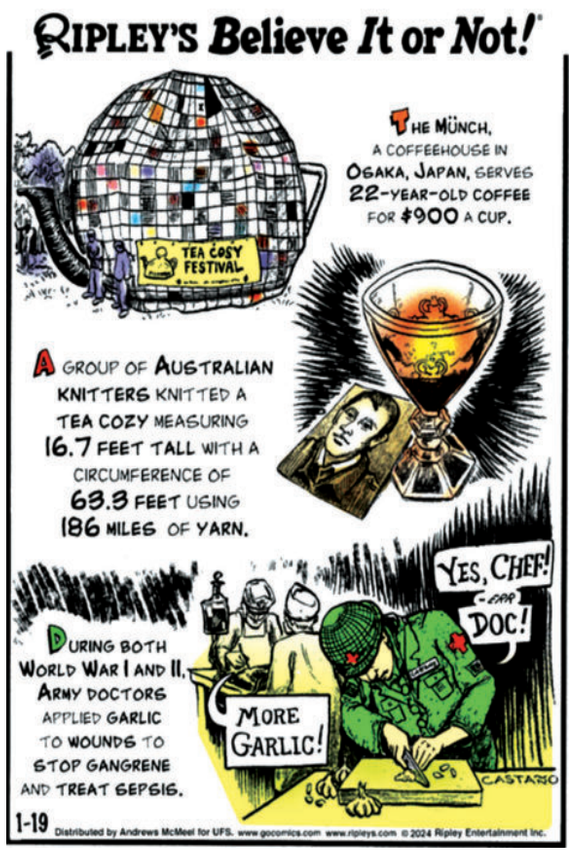
AQUARIUS: The path less traveled is calling to you. You may be afraid to strike out on your own, no matter how little sense it would make for you to follow others' paths.

PISCES: It might be a time of social transition for you. When you look to see what the future holds for you, the waters could be murky -- especially when it comes to community.

CARTOON

gocomics.com





Nepal's U19 eyes to defy odds at the World Cup

BY NAYAK PAUDEL
Kathmandu, Jan. 19



The 15th edition of the ICC U19 Men's Cricket World Cup kicked off on Friday with the host South Africa facing West Indies in Potchefstroom and Ireland vs USA in Bloemfontein.

Ireland and the USA are in Group A with Bangladesh and title-defender India while South Africa and West Indies are in Group B with England and Scotland.

Nepal, who is in Group D with Pakistan, Afghanistan and New Zealand, will play its first match of the group stage against younger Black Caps at Buffalo Park, a cricket ground in East London, South Africa.

It is not the first time that Nepal's U19 team has faced the three opponent teams in Group D. Pakistan and Afghanistan, alongside India, were in Group A of ACC U19 Asia Cup 2023 held in December in Dubai.

However, Nepal lost all three matches in the group stage. Pakistan won by seven wickets with 142 balls remaining and Afghanistan defeated Nepal by 73 runs. The defeat against India was the poorest one as Nepal was bowled out at 52 runs after having given to bat first, and India chased the target in 7.1 overs without losing any wickets.

Nevertheless, Nepal's young guns have been able to defy the odds several times, especially at the World Cup stage.

Nepal defeated New Zealand and Ireland in the group stages of the ICC U19 World Cup in 2016. Nepal won by 32 runs against New Zealand and by eight wickets (with 147 balls remaining) against Ireland. The only loss for Nepal in the group stage was against India. The team also failed to win any of the games in the playoffs as it faced Bangladesh, Pakistan and Namibia.

A young Nepali team has been able to register wins against better teams in the early years as well. When Paras Khadka and Shakti Gauchan were in the U19 team, Nepal defeated South Africa in Chattogram in 2004. Chasing a target of 157, Gauchan combined with No. 11 Sashi Kesari after the ninth wicket fell at 138 runs. The partnership of the final wicket helped Nepal bag the win with one wicket and two balls to spare.

In 2006, Nepal became the Plate Champions after defeating New Zealand's U19 team comprising the likes of Martin Guptill, Tim Southee, Colin Munro and Hamish Bennett. New Zealand had put on 204 after batting first. Basant Regmi was the star for Nepal with the ball as he picked up three wickets. Moreover, Regmi's significant role with the bat and a resilient last-wicket partnership guided Nepal to a close win, securing victory with two balls in hand.

Nepal's current young team will also be trying to win as many matches as possible and reach as high as they can in the tournament.

According to the ICC, captain Dev Khanal and experienced youngster Gulshan Jha, both of whom have appeared for the Nepali senior team, will be the players to watch from Nepal in the tournament.

The ICC has also identified Arjun Kumal and Durgesh Gupta as the players to watch. "Arjun Kumal has put together several knocks across warm-up play and the ACC U19 Asia Cup, while Durgesh Gupta is a left-arm seamer who has impressed in junior domestic cricket," ICC states.

In warm-up matches before the tournament kicked off, the Nepali team showed it was ready for the World Cup. Nepal defeated Scotland by 135 runs.

Nepal was bowled out at 284 runs in 49.2 overs. The target was a result of Gulshan Jha's brilliant innings of 114 runs from 115 balls alongside Dipak Bohara's unbeaten 58 runs off 54 balls. Scotland was bundled for 149 runs as Tilak Bhandari took three wickets and Aakash Chand bagged two.

The team also defeated Namibia by six runs. Nepal was able to defend a low target of 142 runs in a match reduced to 30 overs. Namibia was bowled out at 135 runs in 29.5 overs.

A warm-up match with West Indies on January 16 was called off due to rain. Only 10 overs of the first inning were played. Electing to field first, Gulshan Jha was able to take one wicket in the match where West Indies took the score to 33 before it was interrupted by rain.

After facing New Zealand on January 21, Nepal will face Pakistan and Afghanistan on January 24 and 27 at Buffalo Park respectively with a determination to qualify for the playoffs as one of the top two teams in the group.

Ashutosh shines with century as Bagmati wins over Koshi



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 19

Bagmati Province's opener Ashutosh Ghiraiya fell short of eight runs in one of the opening matches of the PM Cup Men's National Cricket Tournament against Nepal Police Club on January 13 at the TU International Cricket Ground.

Four matches later, Ghiraiya succeeded in scoring a century as the team faced Koshi Province at the same ground on Friday. He scored 41 in the second match against APF, 8 against Madhes and only two runs in the previous match against Tribhuwan Army.

Bagmati was called to bat first as Koshi elected to field after winning the toss in the only match on Day 7.

Ghiraiya, who has not preferred to run in the five matches he has played in this tournament, showed his love for boundaries against Koshi. He opened his account with a four in the third ball he faced and continued hitting 15 more in a total of 111 balls he faced. Ghiraiya also hit two towering sixes before getting caught in 32.1 overs at 118 runs.

Ghiraiya was also favoured by luck as he was dropped in one of the many mis-fields by Koshi. Sujan Thapaliya dropped Ghiraiya's catch when he was at 45 runs after dropping Ishan's.

Captain Rit Gautam and Rabin Joshi were also good with the bat but failed to reach their half-centuries by one and seven runs respectively. Gautam was also dropped on four runs by Avyash Timsina while Rabin was dropped twice. Sonu Ansari also dropped a catch when Ashok Poudel was batting.

Bagmati was at 251 runs in 42.4 overs after Joshi was finally caught as the fifth wicket. The bottom order could not score much and the team was bundled at 273 runs in 48.3 overs.

Avyash Timsina bagged three wickets for Koshi while Kamal Khatri and Hemant Rai claimed two each.

Koshi started the chase against Bagmati differently compared to the previous four matches. However, it lost its fifth consecutive match in the tournament.

Koshi was seen eager to play all 50 overs in the chase despite the chances for the approach to lead to a loss. Openers Sonu Ansari and Ankit Subedi, who is also Koshi's captain, faced 42 and 65 balls to score 21 and 53 runs respectively. Subedi was expected to open his hands more after the half-century but was caught by Pratish GC.

Meenash Thapa, who came in after Ansari went back to the pavilion as the first wicket, was run out at a score of 0 after facing only one ball.

Sujan Thapaliya then entered the crease and raised hope for Koshi. Thapaliya hit a half-century before getting bowled by Surya Tamang at a score of 59 runs off 76 balls. Thapaliya hit four fours and three sixes.

Aaish Bhattarai remained not out at 32 runs off 38 balls in the match where Hemant Rai was the only other batsman for Koshi to score in two digits.

Failing with the bat, Bagmati's other opener Ishan Pandey took a fifer in the eight overs he bowled. He only gave 39 runs. Surya Tamang bagged two and Rijan Dhakal and Pratik Shrestha claimed one each to bowl out Koshi at 209 runs in 47.1 overs.

Bagmati has now climbed to the second position in the table with three wins in five matches. Koshi is at the bottom.

PHOTO: CAN
Bagmati's Ashutosh Ghiraiya celebrates his century against Koshi at TU International Cricket Ground on Friday.

KAA GENT AND MACCABI HAIFA TO FACE OFF WITH NO FAN IN BELGIUM

AP
Brussels, Jan. 19

A soccer match between KAA Gent and Maccabi Haifa scheduled next month in Belgium should be played without fans because of fears of serious riots linked to the Israel-Hamas war, local authorities have ruled. According to Belgian media reports, Ghent mayor Mathias De Clercq took the decision on the advice of local police.

Gent will host the Israeli club on Feb. 21 in the second leg of their Conference League playoff.

"Based on police information, serious problems are expected," said Thomas Dierckens, a spokesperson for Mayor De Clercq, as quoted by Flemish newspaper Het Nieuwsblad.

"The KAA Gent Arena has no outer perimeter, which makes control difficult, and there is a good chance that public order in and around the stadium will be disrupted. This not only has consequences for the safety of fans and players but also sporting consequences," he said. "If the match is stopped for more than half an hour due to disruption, UEFA will give KAA Gent a forfeit score of 0-5." Protests calling for a cease-fire in the war have been taking place regularly in Ghent. Last week, pro-Palestinian activists reportedly disrupted the city's New Year's reception.

Gaza's Health Ministry says more than 24,400 Palestinians have died since the start of the war, and the United Nations says a quarter of the 2.3 million people trapped in Gaza are starving. In Israel, around 1,200 people were killed during the Oct. 7 attack by Hamas that sparked the war and saw some 250 people taken hostage by militants.

Juve playing 'cops and robbers' with Inter as Roma begin De Rossi era

AFP
Milan, Jan. 19

Massimiliano Allegri's Juve can put pressure on Inter with a win at Lecce in a title race the coach inelegantly described as "cops and robbers".

"The robbers runaway and the cops give chase. If there is someone in front there has to be someone behind them," said Allegri after last weekend's 3-0 thumping of Sassuolo. That was a remark which did not go down well with Inter fans, whose team are trying to retain the Italian Super Cup and who consider Juve their biggest rivals.

Inter do not have a league fixture this weekend due to their commitments in Riyadh, meaning that Juve can take advantage and move top of the pile by a single point.

Juve are on a six-match winning streak in all competitions and success at mid-table Lecce, where they will have almost a full squad at their disposal, would leave a potentially tired Inter playing catch-up with the Champions League last 16 also on the horizon.

Inter don't play what would have been this weekend's fixture with Atalanta until the end of February and when come back to Italy they have to travel to top four-chasing Fiorentina. That tough fixture, a week on Sunday, comes a day after Juve's next home match with struggling Empoli where a four-point gap could be opened up.



And the following week Inter host Juve in what could be a crucial match in this season's title race which is looking increasingly like a two-team affair.

Allegri has created a solid outfit, with plenty of team spirit, which has in recent weeks suddenly started to bang in the goals after weeks of grinding out results.

And with no European football this season – the result of the accounting scandal which dominated last season and led to a hefty points deduction – Juve won't have any other distractions from their Scudetto bid.

The weekend kicks off with De Rossi achieving his dream of taking his place on the Roma dugout, the former captain of the capital club coming in for Saturday's home clash with struggling Verona after the shock sacking of Jose Mourinho.

Mourinho was dismissed on Tuesday with Roma languishing in ninth place after last weekend's 3-1 defeat at AC Milan.

However, only five points separate them from the Champions League positions, and De Rossi is confident that his team can make up that gap.

"I think this is a good team with very good players. Even the best sometimes go through difficult periods... I think we've got everything to get back up the table," said De Rossi in an interview with Roma's official channels.

De Rossi will also have to deal with a large chunk of Roma's supporters protesting Mourinho's sacking and pointing the finger at the Friedkin family who own the club – hardly the ideal atmosphere with which to start his first major managerial job.

Basaksehir ends contract with Karzev overs his posting on Gaza hostages

AP
Ankara, Jan. 19



Turkey's leading soccer club Basaksehir announced Thursday it has ended its contract with Israeli player Eden Karzev following a disciplinary probe of his social media post calling for the release of hostages held in Gaza by the Hamas militant group.

The club's decision came days after another Israeli player, Sagiv Jehezkel, was briefly detained in Turkey and questioned for allegedly inciting hatred after he expressed solidarity with the hostages after scoring an equalizer during a top-division game. The Antalyaspor winger returned to a cheering crowd in Israel on Monday from the Turkish coastal city of Antalya where he played.

Karzev was also briefly questioned by police in Istanbul after he re-posted a message on social media that marked the hostages' 100 days in captivity with the hashtag "BringThemHomeNow."

Basaksehir then launched a disciplinary inquiry on the grounds that his action was "contrary to our country's sensitivities." "In accordance with the clubs' disciplinary instructions, the player was fined and it was deemed appropriate that he continue his career abroad," Basaksehir said in a statement after the probe.

The two Israeli players' actions were considered to be supportive of Israel's offensive in Gaza even though both Jehezkel and Karzev said their messages were intended as calls for an end to the Israel-Hamas war that erupted after the unprecedented Oct. 7 attack by Hamas and other militants from Gaza on southern Israel.



PHOTO: HOMRAJ RANABHAT/TRN
Gandaki Province Sports Council is testing the possibilities of developing kayaking, a watersport, on the Narayani River in Nawalparasi East district. The council informed the tests were successful.

WEATHER

Saturday

Sunrise at 6:55 am, Sunset at 5:34 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Saturday)

Partly to generally cloudy in the hilly areas and mainly fair in rest of the country. Chances of light snowfall at one or two places of the high hilly and mountainous region of Koshi Province, Gandaki Province, Karnali Province and Sudur Pashchim Province.

Expected Temp.: 16 - 18°C
Rain Probability: ...%

Friday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dadeldhura	15.4	2.8	0.0
Dipayal	21.5	4.1	0.0
Dhangadi	11.4	9.6	0.0
Birendranagar	21.1	4.5	0.0
Nepalgunj	12.8	10.0	0.0
Jumla	14.0	-5.3	0.0
Ghorahi	16.6	6.7	0.0
Pokhara	18.5	7.1	0.0
Bhairahawa	18.9	11.2	0.0
Simara	20.1	11.5	0.0
Kathmandu	17.4	5.0	0.0
Okhaldhunga	14.7	4.7	0.0
Taplejung	14.5	5.0	Traces
Dhankuta	20.5	6.2	0.0
Biratnagar	18.8	10.2	0.0
Jomsom	9.0	-4.0	0.0*
Dharan	20.5	8.5	0.0*
Lumle	14.0	4.0	0.0*
Janakpur	19.8	9.8	0.0*
Jiri	13.9	-1.1	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

January 20, 2024

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.61	Rs. 133.21
Euro	1	Rs. 144.40	Rs. 145.05
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 168.22	Rs. 168.98
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 152.63	Rs. 153.32
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 87.46	Rs. 87.85
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 98.43	Rs. 98.87
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 98.92	Rs. 99.37
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 8.96	Rs. 9.00
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.44	Rs. 18.52
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.36	Rs. 35.52
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.38	Rs. 36.54
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.74	Rs. 3.76
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.11	Rs. 36.27
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 28.11	Rs. 28.24
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 9.95	Rs. 9.99
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 12.69	Rs. 12.75
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.36	Rs. 19.45
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 16.96	Rs. 17.04
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 430.80	Rs. 432.75
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 351.82	Rs. 353.41

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

Published by Executive Chairman **Bishnu Prasad Subedi** and General Manager **Lal Bahadur Airi** for the Gorkhapatra Corporation • Printed at G.S. Press, Kathmandu • Acting Editor-in-Chief: **Bhimsen Thapaliya**
Phone: Editorial 5322279 • Advertisement 5327493, 5331394 • Distribution 5320638 • E-mail: mgorkhapatra@gmail.com, trnfeatures@hotmail.com • Registered No. 29/028/022 • G.P.O. 30/053/54